

Michael Browne
michael.browne@thinkdigit.com

Recently, we paid a long overdue visit to a friend who posts introductions to his family. He proudly showed us his new 4 Mbps Airtel broadband connection. During our visit, we saw his parents taking turns at the PC. Even his older brother wanted to have a go, his (much slower) data card and netbook forgotten. Upon asking his pained reply was that now that tasks like watching videos on YouTube, downloading music and playing games were a snap, everyone wanted to have a go, and the only time he got on his PC was when everyone went to bed, after 11.30 pm. Do you face a similar situation? Or, do you live

alone, but have multiple gadgets vying for some 4 Mbps love?

A wireless router may not cure your family's data glut, but it will help you share a single internet connection. You could be downloading content on your PC, surfing on your notebook, as well as updating your phone over a single Internet connection wirelessly, so that you can move around your house amidst it all. Or, you could stream a movie from your PC in your bedroom to your TV in the hall. That's not all – a router will provide an additional layer of security for all the devices connected wirelessly to it, preventing unwanted access and potential hackers.

This year, we see an emerging trend for small routers with support for connecting to 3G data

cards. While none of the routers had data cards slots built in, some had a USB port that was only meant for a data card, and doesn't work with regular thumb drives or external HDDs. Sharing a single 3G connection wirelessly might not seem a big deal at the moment, given the relatively poor 3G coverage in India, but as this changes, such devices will surely gain popularity. Another rising trend is the inclusion of a USB media slot to connect to external drives, for media streaming. The 802.11n standard is responsible for this change, because now, given the extra bandwidth, it is possible to comfortably stream even full HD 1080p content, from a PC to a notebook, to your HDTV and not to mention setting up a wireless media server without a NAS drive.

ADSL: WHERE RJ11 AND RJ45 MEET

These routers have inbuilt modems and their WAN port is the RJ11 type that is the same as your landline telephone cable. Basically an ADSL router is for you if your ISP provides your connection via a telephone line. If your internet interface is RJ45 (LAN) based you will be better served by a regular router whose WAN port is also RJ45. ADSL routers are becoming a little rare, and most manufacturers will have only one or two models, most of them without any of the advanced features such as USB port(s), and dual simultaneous band. We received four ADSL routers and they were all basic models, although all supported the latest 802.11n protocol. Since

Share without a Care

With faster broadband plans, and more and more people getting hooked to social networking and the internet, routers are making a strong comeback. In this test, we pit 30 of the best routers against each other, with the sole intention of finding you the right one

